

How I Balance

A New Balance Spring/Summer 2026
Influencer Campaign

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12

CREATORS

S/S 2026

SEASON

8 Weeks

DURATION

\$185K

EST. BUDGET

THE INSIGHT

New Balance has become the brand for people who refuse to choose between performance and personal style. Their audience doesn't separate who they are on the court from who they are off it. The sneakers they train in are the same ones they style with. The athletes they follow are the same ones setting trends. The line between sport and lifestyle isn't blurring for New Balance consumers. It's already gone.

THE OPPORTUNITY

A Spring/Summer 2026 influencer campaign that positions New Balance as the brand that lives in the space between sport and style by partnering with creators who authentically embody that duality: athletes who are also cultural figures, and lifestyle creators who are also athletes at heart.

How I Balance.

Campaign Concept

'How I Balance' is a creator-driven campaign celebrating individuals who define their own equilibrium between sport, style, and daily life. Each creator shares their personal version of 'balance' through authentic content that features New Balance product organically integrated into their real routines, not staged shoots. The campaign runs across Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube over 8 weeks during the Spring/Summer 2026 season.

Campaign Objectives

- Drive brand awareness among 18-34 year olds at the intersection of sport and lifestyle culture
- Generate 25M+ earned impressions across campaign creators within the 8-week window
- Achieve an average engagement rate of 5%+ across all campaign content (above industry benchmark of 2-3%)
- Increase New Balance social mentions by 15% during campaign period vs. prior 8-week window
- Build a reusable creator roster that can extend into Fall/Winter 2026 and become long-term brand partners

Target Audience

Primary: 18-34 year old men and women who identify as both athletes and style-conscious consumers. They follow sports but also care about how they dress. They don't see sneakers as just performance gear or just fashion. They see them as both. They shop based on authenticity, cultural relevance, and peer influence more than traditional advertising.

Secondary: 25-44 year old lifestyle consumers who gravitate toward New Balance's heritage and quality positioning. They value craftsmanship, understated design, and brands that don't try too hard.

Key Markets

New York, Los Angeles, Philadelphia, Chicago, Atlanta. These five cities represent the highest concentration of New Balance's target audience at the intersection of sport and street culture.

The Right Voices, Not the Loudest Ones.

Tier Structure

TIER 1: ATHLETE CREATORS

2 creators | \$30-40K each

Professional athletes who have genuine cultural influence beyond their sport. They set trends, they have personal style, and their audience follows them for who they are, not just what they do on the field or court. These are the campaign anchors.

TIER 2: LIFESTYLE/CULTURE CREATORS

4 creators | \$15-20K each

Mid-tier creators (100K-500K followers) in fashion, fitness, and culture who already wear New Balance organically. Their audience trusts their taste. They bridge the gap between the athlete tier and the community tier, giving the campaign credibility in style-forward spaces.

TIER 3: COMMUNITY CREATORS

6 creators | \$5-8K each

Micro-influencers (10K-100K followers) with high engagement rates who represent specific communities and cities. They bring authenticity at the local level: the pickup basketball player in Philly, the marathon runner in Brooklyn, the yoga instructor in LA who wears 550s to brunch. These creators generate the highest engagement rates and the most genuine audience trust.

Selection Criteria

- Authentic connection to New Balance (already wears the brand organically, not just for paid posts)
- Audience alignment with target demo (18-34, sport + lifestyle crossover)
- Engagement rate above 4% (prioritizing community trust over raw follower count)
- Content quality and consistency (feed aesthetic, caption quality, video production value)
- Cultural relevance in at least one key market (NYC, LA, Philly, Chicago, Atlanta)

The Roster.

Tier 1: Athlete Creators

Tyrese Maxey

ATHLETE

@tyaborhood | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 2.8M | Engagement: 3.2%

Sixers guard with massive cultural crossover. Known for personal style off the court and genuine community connection in Philadelphia. Young, aspirational, and already resonates with Gen-Z sports fans.

Coco Gauff

ATHLETE

@cocogauff | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 3.1M | Engagement: 4.1%

Tennis star who represents the next generation of athletes who are equally known for their style as their sport. Authentic, vocal, and deeply connected to her audience. Cross-sport appeal broadens campaign reach.

Tier 2: Lifestyle/Culture Creators

Aimee Song

LIFESTYLE

@aimeesong | Instagram + YouTube

Followers: 720K | Engagement: 3.8%

Fashion and lifestyle creator who blends athleisure with elevated personal style. Her audience trusts her product recommendations. Known for making athletic brands feel fashion-forward.

Wisdm

LIFESTYLE

@wisdm | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 380K | Engagement: 5.2%

Sneaker culture and men's fashion creator with deep knowledge of New Balance heritage. His audience is exactly the 18-34 male demo that lives at the sport/style intersection.

Natalie Mariduená

LIFESTYLE

@nataliemariduená | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 460K | Engagement: 4.5%

Lifestyle and fitness content creator whose audience skews 18-28 female. Organic athleisure style that aligns perfectly with New Balance's aesthetic. Strong engagement in LA market.

Carlos Saintilus

LIFESTYLE

@carlossaintilus | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 210K | Engagement: 6.1%

NYC-based fitness and fashion creator who regularly styles New Balance in street-meets-gym content. High engagement rate signals genuine audience trust.

Tier 3: Community Creators

Philly Run Collective

COMMUNITY

@phillyrc | Instagram

Followers: 28K | Engagement: 8.4%

Philadelphia running community with hyper-engaged local audience. Represents the grassroots athletic community that New Balance was built for. Authentic product integration through real training content.

Jasmine Torres

COMMUNITY

@jasminefit_ | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 45K | Engagement: 7.8%

Chicago-based fitness and wellness creator. Her content mixes workout routines with personal style in a way that feels native to New Balance's brand voice. Strong female demo reach.

Marcus Chen

COMMUNITY

@marcuschenstyle | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 52K | Engagement: 7.2%

LA-based menswear creator who specializes in casual-athletic hybrid looks. Already features New Balance 990s and 2002Rs organically. His audience values understated quality over hype.

Brooklyn Hoops

COMMUNITY

@brooklynhoops | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 35K | Engagement: 9.1%

NYC pickup basketball culture account documenting runs across Brooklyn courts. Raw, authentic sports content. Perfect for integrating New Balance basketball product into real community moments.

Ava Rodriguez

COMMUNITY

@avarunss | Instagram

Followers: 18K | Engagement: 8.9%

Atlanta-based marathon runner and lifestyle creator. Documents training alongside daily style. Small but fiercely loyal audience. High conversion potential for performance product.

Jordan Li

COMMUNITY

@jordanli.fit | Instagram + TikTok

Followers: 62K | Engagement: 6.5%

NYC fitness and streetwear creator who blends gym content with sneaker culture. Already owns multiple New Balance silhouettes. His audience engages with product content at above-average rates.

Three Content Pillars.

1. How I Balance

Each creator shares a personal piece of content answering the question: 'How do you keep your balance?' This is the emotional anchor of the campaign. It's not about the shoe. It's about the person wearing it and how they navigate the space between performance and personal identity. Each piece closes with the tagline: 'That's how I keep my balance.' Format: 60-90 second Reel or TikTok, or carousel post with long-form caption.

2. In Motion

Creators document themselves in their element: training, competing, running, playing. New Balance product is featured naturally as part of the action, not posed or staged. This pillar drives performance credibility. Format: Short-form video (15-30 seconds), Stories series, or photo dump carousel.

3. Off Court

The lifestyle side. Creators show how New Balance fits into their daily life outside of sport: the coffee run, the commute, the weekend fit. This pillar bridges the gap between athletic and lifestyle audiences. Format: Static photo post, outfit-of-the-day Reel, or day-in-my-life vlog.

Deliverables Per Creator

Tier 1 (Athletes)

2 Feed Posts + 2 Reels/TikToks + 3 Stories + 1 YouTube Integration

Tier 2 (Lifestyle)

2 Feed Posts + 1 Reel/TikTok + 3 Stories

Tier 3 (Community)

1 Feed Post + 1 Reel/TikTok + 2 Stories

What the Content Actually Looks Like.

Concept 1: 'How I Balance' Anchor Video (Tier 1)

Creator: Tyrese Maxey

A 90-second Reel that follows Maxey through a full day, each scene featuring a different pair of New Balance. Opens with him lacing up training shoes for a morning workout. Cuts to him in performance basketball sneakers during practice at the facility. Transitions to his pre-game tunnel walk in an off-court lifestyle pair styled with his fit. Each shoe change is natural, never called out. Voiceover in his own words about what balance means to him as a young player figuring out who he is beyond basketball. Final frame holds on his feet as he walks out of the arena. His voice: 'That's how I keep my balance.' No script. Just his voice, his words, his city.

Concept 2: 'Off Court' Carousel (Tier 2)

Creator: Wisdm

A 5-image carousel showing 5 different ways to style the New Balance 990v6 across a single week: gym, office, date night, weekend errands, courtside. Each slide has a one-line caption. Final slide closes with 'That's how I keep my balance.' Captions written in Wisdm's voice, not brand copy. @newbalance #HowIBalance

Concept 3: 'In Motion' Raw Footage (Tier 3)

Creator: Brooklyn Hoops

A 30-second TikTok filmed at a Brooklyn outdoor court. Pickup game footage, squeaking sneakers, trash talk in the background. Camera catches the New Balance logo on someone's feet mid-crossover. No branding overlay. Just real basketball. Caption: 'The court doesn't care what you're wearing. But we do. That's how we keep our balance. @newbalance #HowIBalance'

Concept 4: 'How I Balance' Organic Post (Tier 3)

Creator: Ava Rodriguez

No brief. No shot list. Ava is sent product and given one prompt: post something real after your next run. Whatever she captures, however she captions it, that's the content. The only ask is to tag @newbalance and close with 'That's how I keep my balance' somewhere in the caption. The power of this concept is that it trusts the creator completely, and that trust is what makes community-tier content feel authentic.

8-Week Rollout.

● Week 1-2	Pre-Launch Creator outreach, contracting, and onboarding. Product seeding and gifting to all 12 creators. Creative briefing sessions (virtual). Creators begin wearing product organically before campaign launches publicly.
● Week 3	Soft Launch Tier 3 community creators begin posting 'Off Court' lifestyle content. No campaign hashtag yet. Goal is to seed product visibility organically before the official launch.
● Week 4	Campaign Launch Tier 1 athlete creators drop 'How I Balance' anchor videos simultaneously. Campaign hashtag #HowIBalance goes live. Tier 2 lifestyle creators post first feed content. New Balance owned channels amplify and reshare.
● Week 5-6	Peak Content All tiers posting across all three content pillars. Highest volume of deliverables. Tier 3 community creators drive local engagement. New Balance runs paid amplification behind top-performing organic content.
● Week 7	Community Push Focus shifts to UGC. Creators encourage their audiences to share their own 'How I Balance' moments. Best UGC gets reshared on New Balance owned channels. Drives campaign beyond the paid creator roster.
● Week 8	Wrap + Recap Final creator posts go live. Campaign recap compiled: impressions, engagement, reach, sentiment, top-performing content. Creator relationships evaluated for long-term ambassador potential.

BUDGET ALLOCATION

Where the Money Goes.

LINE ITEM	BUDGET RANGE	% OF TOTAL
Tier 1: Athlete Creators (2)	\$60,000 - \$80,000	32-43%
Tier 2: Lifestyle Creators (4)	\$60,000 - \$80,000	32-43%
Tier 3: Community Creators (6)	\$30,000 - \$48,000	16-26%
Product Seeding & Gifting	\$8,000 - \$10,000	4-5%
Paid Amplification (boosting top content)	\$15,000 - \$20,000	8-11%
Agency/Management Fees	\$10,000 - \$12,000	5-6%
TOTAL ESTIMATED BUDGET	\$183,000 - \$250,000	

KPIS & MEASUREMENT

How We Measure Success.

Earned Impressions

Target: 25M+ across all campaign content

Method: Measured via creator analytics + platform insights

Engagement Rate

Target: 5%+ average across all posts

Method: Likes + comments + shares + saves / reach

Brand Mentions

Target: 15% increase vs. prior 8-week period

Method: Tracked via social listening tools (Brandwatch, Sprout)

Content Volume

Target: 50+ total pieces of campaign content

Method: Across all 12 creators and 3 content pillars

Creator-to-Ambassador Conversion

Target: 4+ creators extended to long-term deals

Method: Based on performance, audience fit, and brand alignment

UGC Generation

Target: 500+ community posts using #HowIBalance

Method: Organic audience participation in Week 7 community push

Why This Campaign Works.

The influencer marketing landscape is saturated with campaigns that feel transactional: product arrives, creator posts, brand reposts, everyone moves on. 'How I Balance' is designed to be different because it starts with authenticity and builds toward community rather than the other way around.

- The tiered creator structure ensures the campaign has both reach (through athlete creators) and trust (through community creators). Neither works without the other.
- The three content pillars give creators enough structure to stay on-brand while leaving room for genuine self-expression. The best influencer content doesn't feel like an ad. It feels like something the creator would have posted anyway.
- The 8-week timeline is intentionally paced. Soft launch before official launch builds organic visibility. Peak content in weeks 5-6 maximizes momentum. The UGC push in week 7 extends the campaign beyond the paid roster.
- The budget prioritizes engagement rate over follower count. Six community creators at \$5-8K each will generate more authentic engagement than one mega-influencer at the same total spend.
- The campaign is built to convert creators into long-term ambassadors, not one-time partners. That's where the real ROI lives: in relationships that compound over multiple seasons.

This project was created by Jacob McLure as a practice exercise in influencer marketing strategy and campaign planning.

It is not affiliated with or endorsed by New Balance.

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